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AP Research Analyzer

Calibrated against official College Board scored samples · Section-by-section feedback · Actionable revision guidance



INEFFECTUAL ARGUMENT

SCORE JUSTIFICATION

This paper earns a 3 because it carries a coherent focus through method, findings, and reasoning, and it does convey a new understanding (Latino immigrants hold overwhelmingly negative perceptions of U.S. immigration policies), but the reasoning is underdeveloped throughout. The gap is identified in the literature review but is imprecisely defined, and the method is described rather than defended — the student explains what the survey did but not why a descriptive survey design specifically addresses the identified gap. The paper does not reach a 4 because the logical progression from gap to method to findings to conclusion has significant holes: the method alignment is questionable, the new understanding is understated and not sufficiently supported by analysis, and limitations/implications are generic rather than substantive.

Word Count ~3,850 \u2014 The paper is below the 4,000–5,000 word target. The method section is the longest section, while the results, discussion, and conclusion are underdeveloped relative to their analytical demands. Expanding the discussion and conclusion sections would both increase word count and address core scoring weaknesses.

TOP PRIORITIES TO RAISE YOUR SCORE

- 1 Build a true Discussion section that connects the specific findings (72%, 59%, 2.8%, 95%) back to the theoretical frameworks in the literature review — especially Vargas's 'linked fate' concept. Right now the findings are reported but not analyzed. Add at least 400 words that explain WHY these findings came out the way they did, what they mean for the scholarly conversation, and how they advance understanding beyond what Lieberman, Mann-Jackson, and Vargas had already established. This is the single most important revision because it directly addresses the core score-3 weakness on Row C.
- 2 Sharpen and anchor the gap statement in the Literature Review. The current gap ('little research has been done on perceptions of immigration policy among Latino immigrants') is too vague to distinguish this study from Vargas (2017), which already examined how immigration policies shape group identity among Latinos. Rewrite the gap to specify what Vargas and others have and have not measured — for example, that prior studies measure downstream effects (mental health, group identity) but not the

perceptions themselves — and explain why measuring perceptions directly constitutes a meaningful addition to the field. This revision is essential for moving from a score-3 to a score-4 on Row A.

- 3 Describe the survey recruitment and distribution process with enough specificity for replication, and add the full list of Likert scale items to the method section (or as an appendix). Right now a reader cannot evaluate whether the 36 respondents were recruited in a way that could be reproduced, or whether the survey items themselves introduced bias. Specifically address: what platform was used, where and how the link was distributed, and whether any recruitment networks (community organizations, social media groups) were used. This revision is essential for strengthening Row B alignment.

RUBRIC ANALYSIS (3 ROWS)

ROW A \U2014 TOPIC, PURPOSE & FOCUS

Carries focus of inquiry through the method, evidence/findings, and reasoning (may still be narrowing scope).

The paper maintains a consistent topical focus — Latino immigrant perceptions of U.S. immigration policy — across all major sections, and this focus is reflected in both the method (survey targeting Latino adults 18+) and the findings (descriptive statistics on perceptions). However, the parameters are not fully narrow in the score-4 sense: the introduction introduces an 'education' framing that is never operationalized, and the research question conflates perceptions of marginalization with perceptions of policy without measuring whether respondents have experienced the former. The gap statement ('little research has been done on perceptions of immigration policy among Latino immigrants specifically') is present but not anchored precisely to the existing literature — for example, the paper does not explain why Vargas (2017), which directly studied how immigration policies shape group identity among Latinos, does not already constitute research in this space. The paper is clearly operating at the score-3 level on Row A: the focus is carried through, but the scope is still being narrowed and the connection to a specific, demonstrated gap in the literature is not fully realized.

ROW B \U2014 METHOD / PROCESS

Describes a reasonably replicable method/process. Alignment between method and purpose may be questionable.

The method section provides enough detail that the general shape of the study could be reproduced — a dual-language online Likert-scale survey administered to voluntary Latino adult respondents, analyzed with descriptive statistics. However, the alignment between the method and the research question is questionable in a key way: the research question asks how policies 'that marginalize and discriminate' shape perceptions, but the survey does not measure whether respondents have experienced marginalization or discrimination — this is assumed rather than tested. This means the stated causal framing (exposure to discrimination → negative perceptions) cannot be addressed by the design as described. Additionally, the recruitment process is not described with enough specificity for true replication (the paper says the survey was 'distributed online' but does not specify the platform, network, or recruitment strategy). The student does attempt to defend the method choice — citing Vargas (2017) and Lieberman (2023) as precedents, and explaining why surveys suit descriptive designs — but these defenses are more procedural than logical. The method earns a score-3 on Row B: reasonably replicable in structure, but the alignment between the method and the specific research question is questionable.

ROW C \U2014 ARGUMENT & NEW UNDERSTANDING

Conveys a new understanding, but reasoning may be underdeveloped or evidence may be insufficient to support conclusion.

The paper does convey a new understanding: Latino immigrants in this sample hold overwhelmingly negative perceptions of U.S. immigration policy (72% negative overall, 59% feeling unsafe, 2.8% feeling treated with respect and dignity), and the paper correctly positions this as adding to a literature that has previously focused on mental health and economic impacts rather than perceptions. The finding that 95% of respondents rely on media and 0% on schools or family is genuinely novel and interesting. However, the reasoning connecting these findings to the broader argument is underdeveloped. The central analytical claim — 'current policy wording and messaging may be creating these negative perceptions' — appears only in the conclusion, is not supported by the evidence presented, and is not connected back to any specific evidence or framework from the literature review (such as Vargas's linked fate or Ryo's racial threat hypothesis). The limitations are largely generic (sample size), and the implications for the community of practice are aspirational ('a more egalitarian immigration debate') rather than specific. This is a characteristic score-3 on Row C: a new understanding is present and stated, but the reasoning does not fully support the conclusion, and the significance of the findings for the field is not adequately developed.

SECTION-BY-SECTION FEEDBACK *(TAP TO EXPAND)*

1 Introduction & Literature Review

ADEQUATE ▼

2 Method / Process / Approach

ADEQUATE ▼

3 Results / Findings

ADEQUATE ▼

4 Discussion & Analysis

WEAK ▼

5 Conclusion & Future Directions

WEAK ▼

6 Bibliography & Citations

ADEQUATE ▼

RECOMMENDED RESOURCES



Galvan & Galvan — Writing Literature Reviews (7th ed.)

Chapter 5 (Guideline 9: Identify gaps, conflicts, and unanswered questions) and Chapter 9 (Synthesizing trends and patterns across studies)

The literature review currently lists findings source-by-source rather than synthesizing them into an argument, and the gap statement does not specify what the nearest existing studies (particularly Vargas 2017) have and have not examined — Chapter 5 Guideline 9 and Chapter 9 directly address both of these weaknesses.



Leedy & Ormrod — Practical Research: Planning and Design (11th ed.)

Chapter 4 (Planning the research design and aligning method with research question) and Chapter 6 (Descriptive research and survey design, including sampling and bias)

The method section describes the survey but does not defend why a descriptive design best addresses the specific research question, and the sampling procedure lacks sufficient detail for replication — Chapters 4 and 6 provide frameworks for both articulating method-question alignment and designing a defensible survey sampling strategy.

You already have access to these resources \u2014 ask Mr. Schmidt if you need help finding them.

\u2190 Analyze Another Paper